

1980 ▶ 1985



In 1983, scientists defined the meter quite precisely as the distance light travels in a vacuum in $\frac{1}{299792458}$ of a second.

1980

Smallpox wiped out

In 1980, the World Health Assembly declared that the lethal disease smallpox (see p.110) had been eliminated. Smallpox was contagious and often resulted in death or blindness. Some 50 million cases of the disease occurred each year in the 1950s, but global vaccination campaigns and public health initiatives helped get rid of the disease.

1981

Artificial skin

American scientists John Burke and Ioannis Yanas invented artificial skin to treat burn victims. They made it using collagen from sharks and cows, along with silicone rubber. The material formed a framework known as a scaffold over a burn or wound, onto which the body could regenerate its own new skin cells.

Artificial skin is removed from a culture dish in which it takes around three weeks to grow.



1982

First CD player

Japanese company Sony launched the CDP-101, the first CD (compact disc) player. It used plastic discs encoded with digital audio data that were read by a laser and converted into sound.

CDs were later used to store other forms of data, such as computer software.



1980



1981

IBM PC launched

American technology company IBM introduced the 5150 computer, more commonly known as the IBM PC (personal computer). It sold rapidly to both offices and the general public. Hundreds of other companies produced additional hardware and programs compatible with the PC's central software, the Microsoft Disk Operating System (MS DOS).

1981

Reusable spacecraft

NASA introduced its first manned, reusable spacecraft with the test launch of the first space shuttle, *Columbia*. Shuttles were launched using rocket engines, but on their return, glided back to Earth and landed like aircraft. Space shuttles made 135 missions into space until the fleet's retirement in 2011.

153.5-ft- (46.8-m-) long external fuel tank was the only non-reusable part

Booster rockets

Space shuttle

